

## Psychopathology: Causal factors/aetiology

- Several perspectives to understand causes
- Different approaches present different perspectives on psychopathology that helps to gain an overall understanding of the topic
- Analogy of the elephant and the six blind men: Is used to show that all perspectives in psychopathology are important. But any one perspective is not enough to understand the overall aetiology. The blind men may be right from their perspectives but none of them get the complete picture.

## Psychodynamic Approach

### Defense Mechanisms:

- The ego's purpose in establishing defense mechanisms is to avoid dealing directly with anxiety provoking, threatening impulses (Freud, 1926)
- Freud first elaborated on the idea of defense mechanisms in 1926 and his daughter Anna further refined and organized the concept (Anna Freud, 1946)
- Defense mechanisms are normal and universally used
- However, when carried to an extreme or used frequently, they lead to compulsive, repetitive, and neurotic behaviour
- The principal defense mechanisms identified by Freud include repression, reaction formation, displacement, fixation, regression, projection, introjection, denial, rationalization and sublimation

### Characteristics of defense mechanisms:

- Operates at the unconscious level
- Distorts reality
- Help to protect against anxiety that may arise from the painful and threatening impulses from the id; conflict between the id and superego
- Protects the individual against feelings that are difficult for the conscious mind to cope with
- For example, if one is faced with a particularly unpleasant work, the mind may choose to forget responsibility in order to avoid the dreaded task
- Note: If these behaviours are displayed consciously then that does not qualify as a defense mechanism

### Repression: The primary defense mechanism

- Also known as "Unconscious forgetting;"
- Pushes threatening/uncomfortable thoughts into the unconscious
- Common in disorders such as Amnesia, Fugue, PTSD
- An employee's unconscious desire to attack his boss during an official meeting remains hidden from his awareness/conscious mind
- Case studies from Psychopathology of Everyday Life: Forgetting of proper names, concealing memories, mistakes in reading/writing/speech,
- Different from suppression – where forgetting happens consciously

### Rationalization:

- Justifying one's unacceptable actions/feelings/motives through acceptable explanations
- Example: Grapes are sour - Story of fox and the bunch of grapes
- Addiction: "I take drugs because my parents drink alcohol"

### Denial: Ignorance is bliss

- Refusing to acknowledge real situation; clinging to false beliefs to avoid anxiety
- Examples: Patient fails to acknowledge that he is experiencing serious symptoms
- "I may like to shop frequently, but I'm not addicted"

### Projection:

- Unacceptable impulses may be attributed onto other things/people
- Example: "I lost the job because the employer was biased"

**Displacement:**

- The shifting of the targets of one's unconscious fears or desires to a usually less dangerous object/person than the original source of conflict
- Release of bottled-up aggressive impulses triggered by humiliation
- Example: Punching the wall after being humiliated by the boss
- Scolding a younger sibling after being reprimanded by a parent

**Reaction formation:**

- Overemphasizing the opposite (of what one is feeling) in one's thoughts and actions
- Examples: A woman who hates her sister reacts with excessive kindness toward her
- A mother who feels hostile towards her own child, checks on her safety throughout the day

**Regression:**

- One regresses to a personality at an earlier phase of life especially safer stages of our lives where there was less responsibility, carefree day to day living such as in childhood
- Example: A 9-year old child regresses to bed-wetting behaviour when she finds her parents giving attention to her newborn sister
- Other examples of regression: Bragging, temper tantrums, sense of entitlement

**Intellectualization:**

- Thinking about events in cold, hard, rational terms to avoid facing natural. unpleasant emotions associated with it
- Distancing oneself from the emotional content and focusing instead on the facts alone
- Example: A parent who learns that their child is dying tries to learn all they can about the disease, prognosis, treatment options. By doing this, they distance themselves from the unpleasant emotional feelings such as grief; Detached/cold behaviour of a prisoner sentenced to life ("I have done wrong; the punishment is justified")

**Fantasy:**

- Tendency to retreat into fantasy in order to resolve inner and outer conflicts
- Example: Day dreaming, delusion of grandeur

**Acting out:**

- Direct expression of an unconscious wish or impulse in action
- Acting out through behavior instead of putting into words
- Deliberate misbehaving (consciously) is different from acting out
- Example: Temper tantrums, Self harm, rebellious behavior in adulthood

**Identification:**

- The unconscious modeling of one's self upon another person's character and behavior
- Assuming the actions/behaviour of an idolized person or group
- Example: I sing and act just like that famous actor, we're both fond of marijuana as well;
- My brother hates school too. He says it's a waste of time"

**Sublimation: A higher level form of defense mechanism**

- Transforming of socially unacceptable desires into positive, socially acceptable motivation and towards societal goals
- These unacceptable urges are usually sexual or aggressive in nature
- Example: art, writing, poetry, sports

**Humour: A higher level form of defense mechanism**

- Using humour to cope with painful events; not all kinds of humour qualify as defense mechanisms
- A rare mature kind of humour versus common humour: Laughing at self and life versus laughing at others explained through theories of humour
- Example: Gallows humour: Humour in the face of extreme tragedy

Summary:

- Defense mechanisms are common
- Helps to protect the individual against anxiety
- Harmful for self and others when this turns into a regular habit
- That may give rise to symptoms and then disorders

Psychosexual development: Developmental theory of early childhood

- Fixation: Development is interrupted at a given stage
- Oedipus complex: Greek mythological character Oedipus, King of Thebes, is destined by fate to kill his father and marry his mother
- Electra complex: Greek mythological character Electra, plotted her mother's and stepfather's murder to avenge the death of her father
- After successful dissolution of the complex, the child begins to relate to the parent (i.e. son to father and daughter to mother) – father/mother may become role model for son/daughter
- Not considered as a major influence on personality by most contemporary psychologists

Interpretation of Dreams: "...I shall bring forward proof that there is a psychological technique which makes it possible to interpret dreams, and that, if that procedure is employed, every dream reveals itself as a psychical structure which has a meaning and which can be inserted at an assignable point in the mental activities of waking life..." – Sigmund Freud

**Dream interpretation**

- Dreams are the "royal road to the unconscious"
- The unconscious manifests itself symbolically in a dream
- Dreams may be made of infantile material, unfulfilled wishes, or past memories that had been repressed
- Dreams have a manifest content and a latent content
- *Manifest Content*: what a person remembers of the dream
- *Latent Content*: underlying hidden meaning-vast underlying
- **Case of Freud's patient: Five year old Hans**
- Freud believed that every dream has a meaning that can be interpreted by decoding representations of the unconscious material
- Clinical evidence for studying the unconscious: Dreams, Slips of the tongue, Material derived from free-association, projective techniques

Freudian slips/Parapraxes:

- Psychological error in speaking or writing
- Cases from Freud's book "Psychopathology of Everyday Life"
- Freudian slips are evidence of some unconscious urge, desire, or conflict
- When ego or superego are not functioning adequately, elements of the id might slip out
- Eg: Saying "I want" instead of "I won't" (when meaning to say "I won't") indicates a hidden, unconscious desire towards the object

**Psychoanalysis: After the initial years**

- Most psychologists during Freud's time were deeply influenced by his theories; however they had disagreements with Freud over some basic issues of his theories
- Many disagreed with Freud on major points; they worked with him for some time and then moved on to develop their own versions of psychoanalytic theory
- These theorists have been called neo-Freudian, in order to differentiate their work from that of Freud's
- Neo Freudians: Carl Jung, Anna Freud, Alfred Adler

**According to this approach, psychopathological behaviours maybe caused by**

Factors in childhood:

- Freud: Problem behaviours arise as a result of conflicts we fail to resolve in childhood
- Adler: Ordinal position of birth, unresolved inadequacies
- Parental indifference, a lack of warmth and affection in childhood

Other factors:

- If one has not learned to strike a balance between the infantile desires of the id and moral standards of the superego
- Conflicts in this process can lead to anxiety
- Habitual use of defense mechanisms

### **Psychoanalytic treatment procedures:**

- Involves unearthing traumatic early experiences, repressed thoughts, anxiety provoking memories
- Therapy is long-term and focuses on exploring unconscious issues through dream analysis, free association, transference
- The goal of psychoanalysis is to make the unconscious conscious and to enable the person to deal with the unconscious urges realistically

Techniques to probe into the unconscious mind:

- **Free Association:** Speaking whatever comes to mind without censoring any thoughts. Psychoanalysts must be able to recognize the subtle signs that something important has just been mentioned.
- **Dream Analysis:** Uncovering unconscious material in a dream by interpreting the content of a dream. Consists of manifest content (what the dream actually contains) and latent content (what the elements of the dream actually represent)
- **Projective Techniques:** Uses the idea that what a person sees in an ambiguous figure reflects his or her personality.
- **Slip of tongue:** May reveal conflicts

The psychoanalyst looks out for themes that might tie information revealed to portray content from the unconscious; and offers the patient interpretations of the causes of the problems. Resistance and transference may occur as a defense.

### **Experiences related to the process of psychoanalysis:**

- **Transference:** Feelings of love or hatred unconsciously felt toward others, are expressed toward the therapist. This allows the client to experience feelings that would otherwise be inaccessible and may provide clues about the client's real feelings about significant others such as a stern mother, an uncaring father, an unwanted child
- **Countertransference:** The therapist's personal conflicts are triggered resulting in the therapist's reaction toward the client that may interfere with objectivity. This is detrimental to the therapeutic relationship; and the relationship is terminated
- **Resistance:** Behaviour that works against the progress of therapy such as canceling appointments, leaving therapy prematurely, are ways of defending against anxiety

### **Contributions of psychoanalytical theory**

- Considered as the first comprehensive theory of personality and psychopathology
- Emphasis on influence of sexual and aggressive impulses, and childhood experiences on behaviour
- Defense mechanisms, unconscious, conscious, preconscious and id, ego, superego – are effective explanations of some psychopathological behaviours
- Emphasis on counselor's role in therapeutic relationship
- Few theorists and theories in psychology have received so much attention

### **Criticism of Freud's work**

- Pessimistic approach
- Pathology based theory i.e. observations based on clinical cases; not representative of population
- Freud's theories (unconscious, etc.) cannot be observed; no controlled studies
- Psychoanalysis is a pseudoscience because it is inherently untestable (Popper, 1957)
- Overemphasis on differences between men and women
- Less concerned with individual identity, choices and growth over one's lifetime
- Lack of cross-cultural support for theory

Contemporary therapy:

- Patient is not placed in the opposite direction of the therapist; they sit face to face
- More work with 'current' issues than projected material and dreams such as current interpersonal relationships than on intrapsychic conflict (except in case of psychodynamic therapy)
- Fewer sessions to help the client cope with a current crisis
- Therapists may refer clients to self-help groups, ask them to do homework between sessions; this was not typically associated with Freudian therapy

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